

20,000 Steps a Day Will Get You Shredded

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Aug 08, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iGqvRLIJVqs> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter argues that walking 20,000 steps daily is the superior fat-loss cardio strategy — easy to fit into a busy schedule, burns 800–1,000 calories, spares muscle and joints, and avoids the hunger rebound triggered by intense cardio.

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Busting the "I'm Too Busy" Excuse 0:00

- Brandon pre-empts the most common objection: "I got work, I got kids, I ain't got time for that."
- His counter: "You are not busier than me."
 - Takes over **50 flights per year**
 - Has a child and spends significant time with him
 - Has a girlfriend, active social life, attends basketball games
 - Runs a business with **30 employees** (~"like having 30 children")
 - Works **80 hours a week**
- Has been a personal trainer for **over 20 years**, trained **thousands of people**
- Point: busyness is either an excuse or a problem of not yet figuring out how to integrate steps — both are solvable

How to Fit 20,000 Steps Into Your Day 1:08

- Brandon lays out a concrete daily schedule that reaches ~20,000 steps:

Walk Block	Duration	Approx. Steps
Morning walk (e.g., along the ocean)	30 min	~3,000
After-lunch walk	30 min	~3,000
After-work walk (family/dog/social)	60 min	~6,000
Hourly 10-min walks during 8-hr workday	10 min × 8 = 80 min	~8,000
Total		~20,000

- The after-work walk is framed as a social activity — bring kids, family, dog, or girlfriend
- The **9-to-5 cheat code**: set an alarm every hour and walk 10 minutes — adds 8,000 steps passively across the workday
- Breaking steps up throughout the day is explicitly better than doing them all at once (see insulin sensitivity section below)

Why Walking Burns Fat So Effectively 1:53

- **20,000 steps burns approximately 800–1,000 calories** for the average person
- Fat loss has one mechanism: burning more calories than you consume — walking directly addresses that
- Many people assume they need running, sprinting, or intense gym cardio to lose fat; this is unnecessary

Walking vs. Intense Cardio: CNS and Muscle Retention 2:15

- Intense cardio (sprinting, HIIT) is **hard on the central nervous system (CNS)**
 - Sprinting is neurologically similar to resistance training — it requires recovery time
 - While recovering, you have less energy available for weight training
- Walking does **not** stress the CNS — zero recovery cost
 - All your energy can be saved for the weight room
- When cutting, preserving muscle is the priority — that requires pushing hard with weights, not cardio
- This is why **many bodybuilders use walking as their sole cardio** during a cut: maximum calorie burn with minimal muscle-wasting stimulus

Glycogen, Energy, and Cutting Performance 3:00

- Intense cardio **depletes glycogen reserves**, reducing available glucose
- Combined with a caloric deficit, this is why people feel weak and tired during a cut — it's not just low calories, it's glycogen depletion on top of that

- Result: less strength and energy in the weight room, more muscle loss risk
- Walking is low-intensity and does **not** significantly deplete glycogen, so gym performance is protected

Joint Health and Injury Risk 3:22

- Intense cardio (sprinting, running) is harder on joints — ligaments, cartilage, tendons
- Brandon is **43 years old** (turning 44 the following month at time of filming) — notes he'd be the oldest player if he were in the NBA or NFL
 - His priority at this age: "preserve my goddamn cartilage"
 - Sprinting risks ACL tears and other injuries even for **pro athletes who are in peak shape**
- Key point: if professional athletes in top condition still injure themselves running, the risk for an out-of-shape person is even higher
- Walking injury risk: extremely low — "I never heard of anybody messing up their ACL from walking"

Insulin Sensitivity and Spreading Steps Throughout the Day 4:11

- Spreading walks throughout the day (vs. one long session) keeps you **more insulin sensitive**
- Greater insulin sensitivity → body utilizes nutrients more effectively → enhances the fat-loss process
- Spreading the activity also makes the effort feel less grueling and more sustainable

The Subconscious Reward Problem with Grueling Cardio 4:35

- Studies show that people who do intense, hated cardio **subconsciously reward themselves with extra food** afterward
 - Example: "I just ran a mile — I deserve a big dessert."
 - This is a documented psychological response, not just an anecdote
- The math kills the effort:
 - Running a mile burns only **~100 calories** for the average person
 - The "reward" dessert can be several hundred calories
 - Net result: caloric surplus despite doing cardio
- "This is why people do tons of cardio and wonder why they're not losing weight."
- **Walking does not trigger this reward response** — a critical behavioral advantage

Diet is still the most important factor. You can walk 20,000 steps and lift weights, but overeating will erase all of it — "like you did nothing."

Diet Is Still King: Calorie and Protein Formula 5:22

- **Calorie target:** Body weight (lbs) × 10 = daily calories — "not one over"
- **Protein target:** 1 gram of protein per pound of **current body weight** (not goal weight)

- Rationale: higher protein maintains maximum muscle during a cut
- Brandon has been **ketogenic for 11 years** (under 50 net carbs/day) but does not prescribe keto to others
 - "I don't care what you do with your fat and carbs" — fill the rest of your calories however you want
- Warns against influencer advice to lower protein and raise carbs:
 - That's anecdotal; **science shows carbohydrates do not build more muscle**
 - A new study (cited at time of filming) showed the ketogenic diet produced **better weight-loss results** when protein and calories were equal
- Protein need increases with age:
 - After your 20s, muscle is naturally lost every year at a faster rate
 - Studies show **older individuals need more protein** to maintain (and especially build) muscle
 - Younger people synthesize protein more efficiently — their lower-protein advice doesn't apply to older adults

Protein Science: Gluconeogenesis and the Thermic Effect 7:39

- Common claim: "Carbs give you energy." Brandon's correction: **glucose** gives you energy — and protein can also convert to glucose
 - This process is called **gluconeogenesis**
 - This is why Brandon still looks "full" on fewer than 50 net carbs/day
- When glucose is unavailable, the body converts fat into **ketones** — an alternative fuel source (hence "ketogenic")
- **Thermic Effect of Food (TEF) — the protein cheat code:**

Macronutrient	Calories Burned During Digestion
Fat	~3%
Carbohydrates	5–15%
Protein	20–30%

- Practical implication: if you eat **100 calories of protein, you only absorb 70–80 of those calories**
 - Analogy: "It's like getting cash back on your credit card."
- This alone is a strong reason to prioritize protein, independent of muscle-building benefits

Free Tool: The RIP Road Map 8:26

- Brandon promotes a free AI-powered tool called the **RIP Road Map** (link in video description)
- How it works:
 - Input: height, weight, age, and a photo of yourself
 - AI analyzes inputs and estimates your **current body fat percentage** (described as "pretty accurate")

- Outputs: exact pounds of fat to lose to reach your goal, a calorie/protein target, and a week-by-week game plan
- Macro flexibility: the tool shows calorie and protein needs; you choose your own carb/fat split
- Described as a "road map" because it projects expected weekly progress if you follow the plan
- **100% free**